

Economic pressures in Tudor England



Grain prices more than tripled between 1490 and 1569, then increased by another 73 percent between 1569 and 1609, making bread more expensive.



Agricultural and building laborers and skilled craftsmen saw their wages decline by about 60 percent over the course of the 16th century.



Between 1536 and 1549, the dissolution of monasteries (and of guilds and hospitals run by religious orders) ended the traditional sources of charity and poor relief.

subject to harsh penalties, such as whipping, the severing of an ear, and eventual execution.

Further legislation in the 16th century added to the severity of punishment and forced vagabonds to take the first job on offer, however dreadful. Disabled beggars who refused to do work in their own homes were sent for punishment to a “house of correction.”

Leaning on the parish

During the Tudor period (1485–1603), the population of England increased dramatically, which, together with rising prices and rock-bottom wages, meant more and more people could not support themselves. Also, Henry VIII's dissolution of the monasteries, whereby he stripped them of their wealth and property, meant that the poor could no longer fall back on the Church for charity. With the system close to collapse, the Poor Law Act was introduced in 1601 to

provide a comprehensive framework for the legal provision of the poor. The law was primarily aimed at helping the “settled” poor—those who found themselves out of work through no fault of their own—and punishing beggars and vagabonds. It brought together all the previous poor law legislation into a single act.

Although the law applied to the whole of the Tudor kingdom, its provisions were applied locally

rather than nationally through 15,000 local parishes. Each parish had to levy a poor rate or tax from property owners to raise money to provide for the needy. Two unpaid parish “overseers” were elected annually to set the poor rate, collect it from property owners (fining those who did not pay), and then dispense money or food to those who needed it—or compel them to work. The law also placed a legal obligation on parents and children to look after each other. Elderly parents, for example, should be looked after by their children.

The law crystallized the idea that the whole of society suffers if the poor suffer. It became the norm to levy a universal tax to provide money to support the poor and vulnerable. The better-off no longer supported the poor out of charity alone. Instead, it was a legal obligation for everyone who could afford to pay the tax to do so.

Dividing up the poor

The 1601 Act established two kinds of relief: “outdoor” and “indoor.” Outdoor relief was the most common and allowed poor

Economic pressures in the 16th century led to a growing number of beggars on Tudor streets. Punishments such as whipping and—for repeat offenders—hanging became common.

